MOVIES ▼

PASSION FOR CINEMA

Anuparna Roy is taking her new film, *Lovers in the Blue Night*, to the Venice International Film Festival



ROY WON THE BEST DIRECTOR AWARD FOR *SONGS OF FORGOTTEN TREES* AT THE LAST YEAR'S EDITION

In Anuparna Roy's village in Purulia, cinema was a forbidden thing. Growing up in a joint family, her father saw it as something "larger than life", not meant for people like them. The first movie she saw in a hall was *Cocktail* (2012), having snuck in against his wishes. But it was Ritwik Ghatak who changed something inside her. "The films *A River Called Titas* and *Meghe Dhaka Tara* got me. I understood that world cinema is different," remembers Roy, the first Indian filmmaker to win the Best Director Award at the Venice International Film Festival last year for her debut feature film, *Songs of Forgotten Trees*. And now she is set to visit the festival (September 2-12) again with her latest, *Lovers in the Blue Night*.

Venice changed how the village saw her, if not how she saw herself. "They live in a small mofussil, and they are receiving calls and validating them and their daughter, and they're liking it." Her mother, she admits, took longer to see clearly. "I considered her weak, I don't know why—it was a socially constructed notion. Now, I've realised she loved me more than my father, and she's the utmost support."

Her new film follows four people on the margins of Mumbai—a gay husband, his wife, a thief, a pimp—each chasing a version of themselves the world won't let them have. The idea began with Amina, a woman who worked in her house. "She told me Karim (her husband) doesn't want to have her in his life, and it broke her heart. I wanted to portray someone trying to fulfil her desires." The rest, she says, are migrants too, chasing their desires, while society demands a different, performative identity.

But how would she like to be remembered 10 years from now? Roy doesn't reach for 'director', pauses, and whispers, "I'd be called a lover, not a filmmaker." ■

—Sukant Deepak

ARTIST ▼

CARVING HER PATH

The Tamil drama, *Selvi*, continues actor Anjali Patil's penchant for characters on the margins

It was 2012-13, when Anjali Patil was basking in the adulation and accolades that came for her work in Prakash Jha's *Chakravyuh* and Telugu film *Naa Bangaaru Talli*. "I was smitten that I am going to be a star," she says. "Instead, I fell flat on my face. Most films which would come to me seemed illogical." It would take nearly a decade for her to realise that she'd have to take charge of her own narrative and create